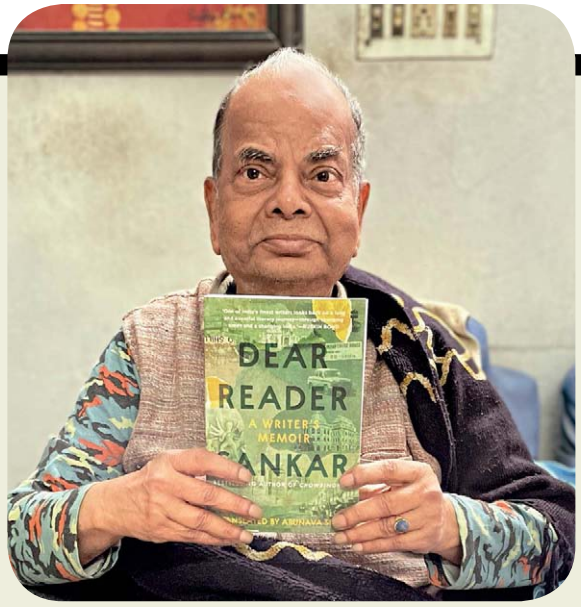


DEAR READER
A Writer's Memoir
by Sankar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹499; 320 pages

BOOKS

LIFE AS HE KNOWS IT

Renowned Bengali author **Sankar's** autobiography, now available in English, is as much about him as the people and the city that made him

IT takes little to sprout a typical, run-of-the-mill Bengali *adda* session. The trappings commonly associated with that pastime—copious cups of tea, a comfortable living room, bowls of snacks—are all optional. Really, all it takes is two people and a topic of mutual interest. But what it absolutely must have—the very best ones, that is—is a storyteller like Sankar.

"He's a raconteur first; a writer second," said Arunava Sinha when I spoke to him about the master minstrel, Manisankar Mukhopadhyay, or Sankar, as he is more widely known. Sankar's autobiographical book *Eka Eka Ekashi* first came out in 2015, and now finds a wider audience in *Dear Reader: A Writer's Memoir*, translated into English by Sinha and released by HarperCollins last month.

On the face of it, *Dear Reader* sees the author looking back on the fascinating events of his long, illustrious life and the people—both famed and obscure—who made the deepest impact on him as a person and as a writer. Within the folds of this narrative, filled with heartfelt anecdotes and reminiscences, we trace the evolution of not just a poor, fatherless, lower middle class boy from Bongram growing up in Calcutta's Howrah district as he navigates the tribulations of 1930s Bengal all the way to literary renown, but also the ever-transient fabric of the City of Joy itself.

In the frank and artless style of an armchair conversation with friends ("Just as an uncomplicated person is everyone's favourite, so too does uncomplicated writing win everyone's hearts," he posits in the book), Sankar paints a telling portrait of Calcutta amidst the major events of the time through his observations and everyday interactions with his betters and peers: the creeping slide of colonial commerce into the seats of power ("The British had made a huge error in giving up shopkeeping to sit on the throne, the two were not the same and couldn't be managed simultaneously," says his neighbour-mentor Badal kaku), Partition ("... in my adolescence I saw grown-ups cutting my country into pieces") and the privations of family poverty exacerbated by global conflict ("My mother would take the ash left over from the clay oven, pound it to a fine dust and store it in an earthen pot. Why not in a tin? ... all tins were on their way to the war").

***DEAR READER* TRACES THE EVOLUTION OF NOT JUST A YOUNG BOY BUT ALSO THE EVER-TRANSIENT FABRIC OF THE CITY OF JOY ITSELF**